

Collaborative Discussion 1 Peer Responses

Abinel Madzivire

Peer Response 1

Dear Mohmmmed Ahmed

I enjoyed reading your discussion and agree with the key points you put forward, particularly your argument that technological advancement does not automatically result in greater fairness, transparency or accountability. Your discussion effectively demonstrates how geographical bias, contextual misinterpretation and surveillance can reproduce existing inequalities when technological systems are treated as neutral.

I particularly agree with your observation concerning techno-solutionism. Technology can provide valuable capabilities, but it cannot independently resolve structural, social or political problems. As Hancock et al. (2024) demonstrate, technological interventions may obscure underlying inequalities when they are designed without sufficient understanding of affected communities. This is reinforced by recent research from Pallí-Asperó et al. (2025), who argue that human-rights-focused AI should incorporate stakeholders throughout the design process. Their findings demonstrate that co-creative approaches can improve explainability, mitigate bias and ensure that technological systems respond to the priorities of affected communities.

Your discussion of surveillance and data misuse is also particularly important. The collection and commercialisation of personal or location data can undermine individual autonomy when meaningful consent and informational control are absent. Carter (2025), for example, argues that strengthening individuals' control over their

information is essential for addressing the privacy risks associated with data-driven surveillance.

I also agree with your emphasis on participatory approaches. Communities should not simply be treated as sources of data or passive recipients of technological solutions. Instead, their lived experiences and contextual knowledge should influence the identification of problems, design of solutions and evaluation of outcomes. Recent scholarship similarly supports stakeholder-driven and participatory AI development as a means of addressing bias and ensuring that systems remain responsive to human needs (Pallí-Asperó et al., 2025). Overall, your discussion provides a strong and well-supported argument for combining technological innovation with human expertise, ethical governance and meaningful community participation.

References

Carter, C. (2025) 'AI surveillance: Reclaiming privacy through informational control', *European Labour Law Journal*, 16(2), pp. 245–258. doi:10.1177/20319525241306327.

Hancock, J. et al. (2024) 'Trouble at Sea: Data and digital technology challenges for maritime human rights concerns', *Proceedings of the 2024 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency*. New York: ACM. doi:10.1145/3630106.3658950.

Pallí-Asperó, C., Evrard, E., Lefever, E. and Destrooper, T. (2025) 'Can human-centred participatory design turn AI into a pertinent tool for human rights research?', *Big Data & Society*, 12(4). doi:10.1177/20539517251396108.

Peer Response 2

Dear Asma Umar

I enjoyed reading your discussion and agree with the key points you put forward, particularly your argument that the digital transformation of human rights investigations creates both significant opportunities and important risks. Your explanation of the “false sense of bright spots” is particularly compelling because it demonstrates how the absence of digital evidence should not necessarily be interpreted as evidence of the absence of human rights violations. This is an important distinction in increasingly data-driven investigative environments.

I also agree with your discussion of the “accountability horizon”. As data passes between investigators, technology providers and other stakeholders, responsibility for errors, misuse or harmful outcomes can become increasingly difficult to establish. This reinforces the need for clear data governance, accountability mechanisms and transparency throughout the technological lifecycle. Recent scholarship similarly highlights that responsible AI requires organisations to move beyond high-level ethical principles towards practical mechanisms for accountability and implementation (Hagendorff, 2024).

Your point about involving affected communities is equally important. Technological systems designed without sufficient consideration of local knowledge may reproduce existing inequalities or exclude individuals who have limited access to digital technologies. Participatory approaches can therefore help ensure that technological interventions reflect the realities and priorities of the communities they are intended to support. Recent research on participatory AI for human rights similarly emphasises

meaningful stakeholder involvement in designing and evaluating AI systems (Pallí-Asperó et al., 2025).

I particularly support your proposed combination of participatory co-design, algorithmic auditing, robust data governance and human oversight. These measures recognise that technology should complement rather than replace human judgement and established investigative practices. Jobin, Ienca and Vayena (2019) demonstrate the importance of common ethical principles, while more recent research indicates that translating such principles into accountable practices remains a significant challenge (Hagendorff, 2024). Overall, your discussion provides a balanced and persuasive analysis of how digital technologies can strengthen human rights investigations while simultaneously creating new forms of risk.

References

- Hagendorff, T. (2024) 'Mapping the field of responsible AI', *AI and Ethics*, 4, pp. 181–193.
- Jobin, A., Ienca, M. and Vayena, E. (2019) 'The global landscape of AI ethics guidelines', *Nature Machine Intelligence*, 1(9), pp. 389–399.
- Pallí-Asperó, C., Evrard, E., Lefever, E. and Destrooper, T. (2025) 'Can human-centred participatory design turn AI into a pertinent tool for human rights research?', *Big Data & Society*, 12(4).

Peer Response 3

Dear Precious Angel Ejekpokpo

I enjoyed reading your discussion and agree with the points you put forward, particularly your argument that governance failures, rather than technology itself, can be the principal source of risk in digital human rights investigations. I found your distinction between technological capability and the organisational assumptions surrounding its use particularly insightful. It highlights an important issue: even highly sophisticated systems can produce unfair outcomes when their design and implementation fail to reflect the realities of affected communities.

I also agree with your emphasis on overconfidence in technological outputs. Digital evidence can appear objective because it is generated through sophisticated algorithms and data-processing techniques; however, the underlying data, assumptions and models may contain limitations or biases. Recent research on responsible artificial intelligence similarly argues that trustworthy AI requires organisations to address contextual and organisational factors rather than focusing exclusively on technical performance (Hagendorff, 2024). Therefore, human judgement and critical evaluation remain essential when interpreting technology-generated evidence.

Your connection to the NIST AI Risk Management Framework is particularly relevant. Governance, stakeholder engagement and continuous monitoring are essential for managing AI-related risks throughout the system lifecycle (NIST, 2023). I would further suggest that human rights impact assessments could provide a valuable mechanism for operationalising these principles, particularly where digital technologies are used to investigate vulnerable populations.

Your recommendation for meaningful community participation is also persuasive. Participatory approaches can help identify risks that technical developers or investigators may overlook because communities possess contextual knowledge that cannot easily be captured through datasets. Pallí-Asperó *et al.* (2025), for example, demonstrate the value of participatory approaches in developing AI applications for human rights research, emphasising stakeholder involvement as a means of improving relevance and accountability.

Overall, your discussion provides a strong governance-centred perspective on technological risk. I agree that achieving fairness and accountability requires organisations to move beyond technical bias testing and embed human rights, stakeholder participation, transparency and continuous oversight throughout the technology lifecycle.

References

Hagendorff, T. (2024) 'Mapping the field of responsible AI', *AI and Ethics*, 4, pp. 181–193.

NIST (2023) *Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework (AI RMF 1.0)*. Gaithersburg, MD: National Institute of Standards and Technology.

Pallí-Asperó, C., Evrard, E., Lefever, E. and Destrooper, T. (2025) 'Can human-centred participatory design turn AI into a pertinent tool for human rights research?', *Big Data & Society*, 12(4).